anxiety about the Chinese threat, and disenchantment caused by US and UK pressure to compromise on Kashmir, reduce the scale of the defence build-up, and refrain from sourcing weaponry from the Soviet Union.[68]

But when China demonstrated its nuclear weapons capability in October 1964, India began to seek a nuclear guarantee from the United States and USSR in particular, as well as from the United Kingdom and France, against Chinese nuclear attack or coercion.[69] In an internal memo, L.K. Jha, who spearheaded that diplomatic effort, noted that a joint superpower declaration would not only allow the United States and USSR "to act without concern that the other would act at crosspurposes" but also "further strength India's deterrence of China."[70] In the event, none of the countries approached was willing to offer an explicit nuclear guarantee.

India's search for an external balancer against China reached a culmination in August 1971, when it signed a 20-year treaty of peace, friendship, and cooperation with the Soviet Union. The key provisions of this treaty were: an explicit pledge of neutrality in the form of not participating in any alliance against the other and not militarily assisting a third country engaged in war with the other and an undertaking to consult each other in the event of an attack "in order to remove such threat and to take appropriate effective measures to ensure peace and security of their countries."[71] In tune with these provisions, during the 1971 India–Pakistan War, "the Soviet ambassador in Delhi secretly pledged that if China intervened against India, the Soviet Union would open its own border diversionary action against China."[72] According to Lt. Gen. J. F. R. Jacob, who served as Chief of Staff in the Indian Army's Eastern Command during that war, "the Soviets moved 40 divisions to the Xinjiang and seven to the Manchurian borders to deter the Chinese."[73] In effect, Nehru's reported statement – "We are